For Punekars, the Lohagad fort on the city's outskirts has always been an attraction, with its easy hike up the hill and breathtaking views of the Sahyadris. Beginning this June, it has acquired another lure: a cliff on the fort's edges from where city-based realtor, Ketan Agarwal, was allegedly pushed to his death by fiancée Siya Goyal and her friend Chetan Chaudhary. Footfalls at the fort have surged and everyone now wants a peek at the gorge from the now-notorious 'Siya Point'.

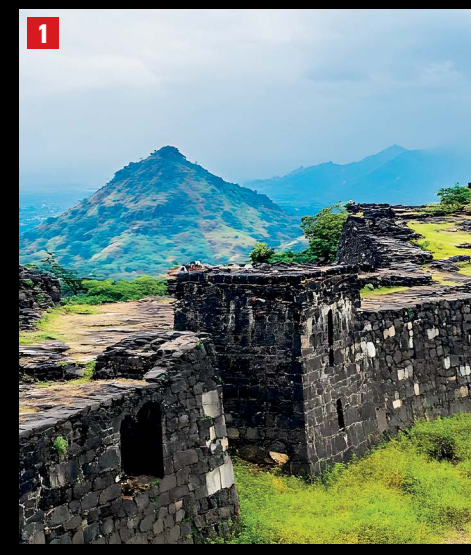
It was a hot morning on June 18, when Siya and Ketan trekked up the hill to the fort. The two were engaged and scheduled to tie the knot in about six months, on November 25. But Siya evidently had other plans, as she and Chetan allegedly pushed Ketan into a 400-foot gorge. While Chetan made a getaway, Siya raised an alarm, claiming that Ketan had slipped and fallen. Rescuers recovered his body later, and the case was registered as an accidental death. Ketan's parents, the Agarwals, even told officials at the Lonavala Rural police station that they did not suspect foul play as they and the Goyals had known each other for decades and were distantly related. But the incident raised several red flags for the police, which prompted the investigation. "The case raised many doubts," says Sandeep Singh Gill, superintendent of police, Pune Rural, "especially since no such accident has ever occurred at Lohagad... the place is considered quite safe."

On June 21, a police officer tracking the couple's movements from the CCTV footage at the fort noticed something unusual—a man wearing a hooded sweatshirt despite the 33-degree summer heat was hovering around them at the ticketing counter and seemed to be communicating with Siya through hand gestures. "The man was wearing headphones over his hoodie, which is unusual if you are listening to music. The camouflage element was evident," claims Gill.

Then there were Siya's conflicting statements on how it all happened. She first told the police that Ketan accidentally slipped while the couple were taking photographs near the edge of the fort amid strong gusts of wind (the police found no photographs taken at Lohagad on Ketan's phone). Later, she claimed they had stopped to rest after the climb, and Ketan lost his balance while handing her a bottle of water. All this was enough for the police to launch a confidential investigation. By then, Ketan's family, too, had begun voicing their suspicions. On June 23, the Pune police arrested Siya and Chetan and remanded them to judicial custody.

A MATCH MADE IN...

It was in February that intermediaries and relatives had proposed a marriage between Ketan, the son of city-based realtor Vishal Agarwal, and Siya, the daughter of Pravin Goyal, a wholesale dealer of dry fruits and masalas at the Pune marketyard. The Goyals and Agarwals had known each other since the 1980s when the latter ran a wholesale business of groceries and dry fruits at the Tuljapur pilgrimage centre in Dharashiv (Osmanabad), some 450 km from Mumbai. Ketan's great-grandfather Kisanlal would stay with the Goyals when he visited Pune to purchase goods from them. Kisanlal's son Devichand—Ketan's grandfather—shifted to Pune two decades ago.


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